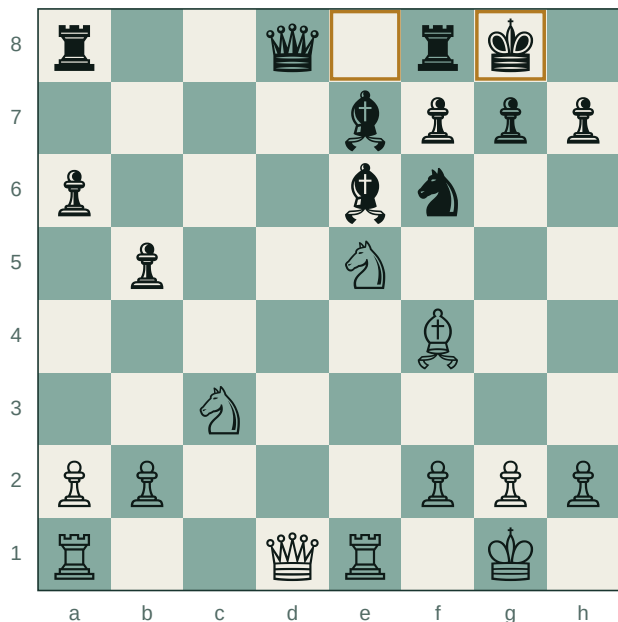


Skewers: White, move 20

Skewers

White to move



Previous move: 19...O-O. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Nc6 Qe8 21. Nxe7+ Qxe7 22. Bd6 Qd8 23. Bxf8

20.Nc6 The knight moves from e5 to c6. From c6 it attacks queen on d8 and bishop on e7. Recorded reply: **20...Qe8**.

21.Nxe7+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on e7. Recorded reply: **21...Qxe7**.

22.Bd6 The bishop moves from f4 to d6. Recorded reply: **22...Qd8**.

23.Bxf8 The bishop captures the rook on f8. The changed line means the queen on d1 attacks the queen on d8.

At the end, nominal material is White 30 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from +0 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The defender may block, capture the attacker, or protect the rear piece while moving the front one. Alignment alone is not enough.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A skewer puts the more important target in front. When that target moves, a piece behind it may be lost. Checks make the geometry especially forcing.

HOW TO LOOK

Search ranks, files, and diagonals where two enemy pieces line up. Calculate the first target's legal responses.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.